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ACADEMIC VAULT

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Nutrition for Students: Eat Well on a Small Budget

Affordable meals that support concentration, energy and health

HEALTH & WELLBEING

Health & Wellbeing

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

Cheap food is not automatically bad food, and expensive food is not automatically balanced. This pack explains the basics of a balanced plate, builds affordable Nigerian meal combinations, and covers hydration, food safety and the effects of caffeine and energy drinks.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Explain the components of a balanced diet and their functions.
- Build affordable meals using locally available foods.
- Apply food-safety practices in hostel and shared kitchens.
- Make informed choices about caffeine, sugary drinks and supplements.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

The balanced plate

You do not need imported foods to eat well.

- Carbohydrates provide energy: rice, yam, plantain, garri, maize, potatoes.
- Proteins build and repair tissue: beans, fish, eggs, chicken, milk, groundnuts.
- Fats in moderation support hormones and vitamin absorption: vegetable oil, nuts, avocado.
- Vitamins and minerals come from vegetables and fruit; include something green or orange daily.
- Fibre supports digestion and steady energy: beans, vegetables, whole grains.
- Water is essential; aim for regular intake through the day, more in heat.

Affordable combinations

Balance is about combination, not cost.

- Beans and plantain with vegetables gives carbohydrate, protein and fibre.
- Rice with beans and a vegetable stew is cheap and filling.
- Pap with milk and groundnuts adds protein to a cheap breakfast.
- Eggs are one of the cheapest complete proteins.
- Buy staples in bulk and share with roommates to reduce unit cost.
- Reduce sugary drinks; they add cost and calories without nutrients.

> **Do not skip breakfast before exams**
> Skipping meals reduces concentration and increases irritability. Even a small protein-containing breakfast improves exam performance compared with none.

Safety and stimulants

Food poisoning can cost you a week of lectures.

- Wash hands and produce; separate raw meat from cooked food.
- Cook food thoroughly and refrigerate promptly where possible.
- Be cautious with street food that has been sitting uncovered in heat.
- Treat water carefully if the source is uncertain.
- Caffeine is not a substitute for sleep; energy drinks cause crashes.
- Supplements are not a shortcut to health and can interact with medication.

Energy is a food problem before it is a willpower problem

The afternoon slump, the inability to concentrate at 4 p.m., and the constant hunger that leads to buying whatever is nearest are usually consequences of what was eaten at 7 a.m. - often nothing. A breakfast with protein and fibre produces a slower rise and fall in blood glucose than a sugary drink and a pastry.

The basic composition matters more than any specific diet: carbohydrates for fuel, protein for repair and satiety, fats for hormones and absorption, fibre for digestion and steady energy, and water for everything. Most student diets are high in refined carbohydrate, low in protein and vegetables, and low in water.

Meal timing shapes energy. Three meals with one or two small snacks suits most people better than one huge evening meal, particularly for concentration during the day.

Eating well on a student budget